confined to its covers."[60] By September 8, 1972, the same week Davis returned to East Berlin on her Eastern bloc tour, the first contract, for a book titled "Education of a Revolutionary," was drawn up with Bantam Books and Bernard Geis Associates. According to the contract, "Said [manuscript] will recount the experiences in the Author's life that shaped her philosophy and influenced her actions … [and] will also include the Author's statement as to where she stands—as a political person, as a black woman, and as a crusader for social justice."[61]

Within weeks, on October 3 of the same year, staffers at Random House, where Morrison was an editor, including editor in chief and publisher James Silberman, met with representatives from Bantam and Bernard Geis Associates. By January, 31, 1973, Random House and Bantam drafted an agreement to copublish the book. According to the updated contract, Random House would take the lead in the hardcover and "day to day editorial functions be carried out by a RANDOM editor," a reference to Morrison's engaged role in the project.[62] The title at that time remained "Education of a Revolutionary," with the first manuscript sections arriving in the spring of 1973. The book was initially separated into three sections: part 1, Flight, Arrest, New York Hail, Extradition; part 2, Childhood, New York, Europe, California; and part 3, Soledad, George Jackson, Trial.[63] Over time, Davis shifted the organization of her narrative.[64] Davis and Morrison worked closely in New York City and spent time outside the United States, including in the Virgin Islands, Cuba, and Europe. As Morrison later recollected, "There was nowhere in the United States where Angela could feel safe and write."[65]

It is not clear from available archives at what point Davis composed the section including Berlin and "the wall."[66] It is evident, however, that the book went through multiple stages of line revisions and refinement, as editor Morrison was pushed to grapple with the question of whether readers would be able to relate to this "political autobiography." For example, in early 1974 serious reservations arose about the book after a scathing reader's report arrived from Bantam. In response, Morrison wrote publisher Silberman a powerful four-page letter on February 1, 1974, addressing the charge that the manuscript contained no "sustenance" and not enough "humanness." In sharp reply, Morrison wrote, "Angela is the fiercest woman I have ever met and I come from a long line of fierce women." She added, "I must emphasize that there are no two Angela Davises. One political, one human.